ENTERTAINMENT

ALL FOR QUALITY

Shahid Kapoor and filmmaking duo Raj Nidimoru and Krishna D.K. talk about their new Amazon Prime Video release, ***Farzi***



IN the early days of shooting their second Amazon Prime Video series, *Farzi* (released on February 10), creators Raj Nidimoru and Krishna D.K. took time to make sense of Shahid Kapoor's working style. Kapoor looks back at those days and thinks that he may have appeared "annoying sometimes". He says, "I was angst-y in my search for Sunny...There were a lot of thoughts in my head." The filmmakers let the 41-year-old actor do his thing and gradually came to appreciate his ability to keep track of events in the show even though it was not being shot linearly. "The story is quite complex, there's a lot to it," says Raj. "He doesn't look it, but he's a thinking actor."

That thinking actor makes his OTT debut with two of the most sought-after filmmakers in India whose thriller series, *The Family Man* (2019—), was wildly successful. It's no surprise then that when Raj and D.K. called Kapoor to pitch a film, he instead asked them whether they had a nifty idea for a longer-format storytelling.

In *Farzi*, Kapoor plays a man revelling in the rewards of making counterfeit notes until the law (read Tamil star Vijay Sethupathi) begins to track his illegal exploits. The flawed genius archetype has its appeal. "Grey characters, if written well, make the audience whistle more than white characters," says Kapoor. That's because "they do [things] in an irreverent, naughty, mean, edgy way", he adds. "They provide an escape to the *aam aadmi* [common man] who sees someone doing everything they feel like doing but can't, because they are either scared or stuck with being nice." However, that's not to say that Sunny has no redeeming qualities. Says Kapoor, "Every grey character has a kind of goodness and humanity to them." Part of the challenge for him is to "find what's human about them while showing everything that might not be typical or nice".

> Shahid Kapoor says he values it when 'A++' content comes his way. So long as the role is new and challenging, it doesn't matter where it's seen

What makes the world of *Farzi* more exciting is that it comes with Raj and D.K.'s trademark flourishes—satire, black comedy and quirks, the essential ingredients that made both *The Family Man* (2019—) and the horror comedy *Stree* (2018) successful. "They definitely have a certain style